

▶ TIME, BENT



Much was expected when Sydney McLaughlin-Levrone committed fully to the 400m flat early in 2025, stepping away from her signature 400m hurdles.

Having already stretched the limits of the one-lap hurdles — she owns the three fastest times in history — the American appeared ready to test herself anew. The looming benchmark was unmistakable: Marita Koch's long-standing women's 400m world record of 47.60 seconds, set in 1985, with the Tokyo World Championships the ideal proving ground.

McLaughlin-Levrone signalled her intent in the semifinals, clocking 48.29 seconds to break the American record. It was a statement run, but the final went further.

On September 18, the 26-year-old produced a performance for the ages, slicing nearly half a second off her own mark to win gold in 47.78 seconds. She became the first woman in 40 years to dip under 48 seconds and erased a 42-year-old championship record previously held by Jarmila Kratochvílová.

The relentless pace also dragged silver medallist Marileidy Paulino into rare territory, as her 47.98 made it the first 400m race in which two women ran under 48 seconds.

McLaughlin-Levrone fell just 0.18 seconds short of the world record, a margin small enough to sharpen rather than dull her ambition heading into the 2026 season.

"I knew there were a lot of people doubting me with the switch from hurdles to the flat 400," she said after her Tokyo triumph. "But I trusted my training. I knew I had it in me."

▶ BEYOND HER YEARS

The Chess World Cup is among the sport's most unforgiving events, its knockout format offering little margin for error.

The 2025 Women's World Cup in Batumi, Georgia, underlined India's growing dominance as two Indians fought their way through a 107-player field to reach the final. While fourth seed Koneru Humpy's presence was expected, her opponent, 19-year-old Divya Deshmukh, emerged as the tournament's surprise package.

Seeded 15th, Divya carved a stunning path to the title match. She began her upset run by eliminating China's second seed Zhu Jiner in the fourth round, followed by victories over compatriot D Harika in the quarterfinals and China's Tan Zhongyi in the semifinals.

Humpy's route was steadier, highlighted by her semifinal win over top seed Lei Tingjie.

The final itself was tense and cautious, with the classical games ending in draws. The breakthrough came in the tiebreaks, where Divya struck in the second game to claim the title and become the youngest-ever Women's Chess World Cup champion.

Along with the biggest win of her career, Divya earned the Grandmaster title and qualification for the 2026 Candidates tournament, confirming her arrival as India's next major chess force.

